28

6 June 1929 and the Rejection of ‘Utopian Non-violence’

Although large portions of the statement that the two of them made were redacted from the record on 9 June 1929, the text that is preserved in the National Archives of India[1] in New Delhi contains the complete version. The statement was originally in eight paragraphs. However, less than half of it was allowed to be put before the Sessions Court and paragraphs 6, 7 and 8 towards the end were almost entirely eliminated. In the expunged paragraph 6, they state that ‘the Imperialist Exploiters cannot succeed’ because ‘by crushing individuals they cannot kill ideas’.[2] After setting out their aims and objectives, they make it clear that ‘[f]or these ideals, and for this faith, we shall welcome any suffering to which we may be condemned’[3]. What were these ideals? And what was this faith?

First, they wished to make it known that ‘[w]e are next to none in our love for humanity and so far as having any malice against any individual we hold human life sacred beyond words’. This being so, ‘[w]e are neither perpetrators of dastardly outrages and therefore to the country, nor are we “lunatics”’. They continue, ‘We humbly claim to be no more than serious students of this history and conditions of our country and human aspirations, and we despise hypocrisy.’[4] These words demonstrate how Bhagat Singh was operating from deep-seated philosophical convictions that informed the nature of his rebellion against the British Raj. In fact, far from Bhagat Singh being a young hot-headed malcontent, it is manifestly plain from this that he stood on par with Frantz Fanon, who was to come much later in the twentieth century. He writes, ‘We dropped the bombs on the floor of the house Assembly Chamber to register our protest on behalf